

LESSON THREE

DISCIPLESHIP

Following Jesus with Commitment and Obedience

ACTS 242 FOUNDATION GUIDE • EDITION 1 • 2026

LESSON 3 OF 7

To understand what it means to be a disciple of Jesus and how that applies to your life.

What is a disciple?

Why does Jesus call people to follow Him?

What does it cost to follow Him?

How should a disciple live?

Jesus did not only call people to believe in Him. He called them to follow Him.

Discipleship is not just learning information about Jesus. It is a life of surrender, obedience, love, and growth.

Are you only listening to Jesus, or are you truly following Him?

Before we open the Bible

What has following Jesus cost you so far?

Write it plainly. If the honest answer is nothing yet, write that.

What is the one thing you would find hardest to give up if He asked?

The Command

MATTHEW 28:18–20 NIV

18 Then Jesus came to them and said, “All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. **19** Therefore go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, **20** and teaching them to obey everything I have commanded you. And surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age.”

Discipleship is not optional. It is the mission Jesus gave to His people.

Making disciples includes baptizing them and teaching them to obey.

Called Christians First at Antioch

ACTS 11:25–26 NIV

²⁵ Then Barnabas went to Tarsus to look for Saul, ²⁶ and when he found him, he brought him to Antioch. So for a whole year Barnabas and Saul met with the church and taught great numbers of people. The disciples were called Christians first at Antioch.

DEFINITION

A disciple is a follower of Jesus who learns from Him, obeys Him, and helps others follow Him too.

UNDERSTAND

Notice how long it took at Antioch: a whole year of meeting and teaching. Discipleship is measured in seasons, not in single decisions.

Jesus Calls His First Disciples

MARK 1:16–18 NIV

¹⁶ As Jesus walked beside the Sea of Galilee, he saw Simon and his brother Andrew casting a net into the lake, for they were fishermen. ¹⁷ “Come, follow me,” Jesus said, “and I will send you out to fish for people.” ¹⁸ At once they left their nets and followed him.

Jesus called ordinary people. Their response was immediate. They left what defined their old life.

A disciple is not self-made. Jesus says, “I will make you.”

Deny Yourself, Take Up Your Cross

LUKE 9:23–26 NIV

²³ Then he said to them all: “Whoever wants to be my disciple must deny themselves and take up their cross daily and follow me. ²⁴ For whoever wants to save their life will lose it, but whoever loses their life for me will save it. ²⁵ What good is it for someone to gain the whole world, and yet lose or forfeit their very self? ²⁶ Whoever is ashamed of me and my words, the Son of Man will be ashamed of them when he comes in his glory and in the glory of the Father and of the holy angels.

TO DENY YOURSELF

- not putting yourself first
- not living by your own will
- not making life all about you

TO TAKE UP YOUR CROSS

- dying to sin
- choosing obedience
- following Jesus even when it is costly

A disciple does not follow Jesus only when convenient. A disciple follows Him daily.

Counting the Cost

LUKE 14:25–33 NIV

VERSES 25 TO 30

²⁵ Large crowds were traveling with Jesus, and turning to them he said: ²⁶ “If anyone comes to me and does not hate father and mother, wife and children, brothers and sisters—yes, even their own life—such a person cannot be my disciple. ²⁷ And whoever does not carry their cross and follow me cannot be my disciple. ²⁸ “Suppose one of you wants to build a tower. Won’t you first sit down and estimate the cost to see if you have enough money to complete it? ²⁹ For if you lay the foundation and are not able to finish it, everyone who sees it will ridicule you, ³⁰ saying, ‘This person began to build and wasn’t able to finish.’

Counting the Cost, continued

LUKE 14:25–33 NIV

VERSES 31 TO 33

³¹ “Or suppose a king is about to go to war against another king. Won’t he first sit down and consider whether he is able with ten thousand men to oppose the one coming against him with twenty thousand? ³² If he is not able, he will send a delegation while the other is still a long way off and will ask for terms of peace. ³³ In the same way, those of you who do not give up everything you have cannot be my disciples.

ACTS 242 SUMMARY

Jesus said anyone who does not put Him first and carry their cross cannot be His disciple. He spoke of counting the cost like a builder planning a tower. He compared it to a king preparing for battle. He said anyone who does not give up everything cannot be His disciple.

Jesus never hid the cost of following Him. To count the cost means understanding that Jesus must come first, accepting that following Him will require sacrifice, and choosing Him above comfort, pride, and control.

KEY TRUTH

**A disciple does not add
Jesus to life. A disciple
gives life to Jesus.**

Teach Us to Pray

LUKE 11:1-4 NIV

¹ One day Jesus was praying in a certain place. When he finished, one of his disciples said to him, “Lord, teach us to pray, just as John taught his disciples.” ² He said to them, “When you pray, say:

“Father,
hallowed be your name,
your kingdom come.

³ Give us each day our daily bread.

⁴ Forgive us our sins,
for we also forgive everyone who sins against us.
And lead us not into temptation.”

A disciple grows in relationship with God. Notice what the disciples asked for. They did not ask for a method of ministry. They asked to be taught to pray.

What does your prayer life look like in an ordinary week, not at its best?

The Greatest Commandment

MATTHEW 22:34-40 NIV

³⁴ Hearing that Jesus had silenced the Sadducees, the Pharisees got together. ³⁵ One of them, an expert in the law, tested him with this question: ³⁶ “Teacher, which is the greatest commandment in the Law?” ³⁷ Jesus replied: “Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind.’ ³⁸ This is the first and greatest commandment. ³⁹ And the second is like it: ‘Love your neighbor as yourself.’ ⁴⁰ All the Law and the Prophets hang on these two commandments.”

A disciple learns to pray, to love God fully, to love others sincerely, and to live under God's will.

Discipleship is not only about activity. It is about a life centered on God and shaped by love.

The Mark of a Disciple

JOHN 13:34–35 NIV

³⁴ “A new command I give you: Love one another. As I have loved you, so you must love one another. ³⁵ By this everyone will know that you are my disciples, if you love one another.”

The true mark of a disciple is love, not just knowledge, not just words, not just church activity.

People should be able to see Jesus in the way His disciples love.

Answer Honestly

Am I truly following Jesus, or only agreeing with Him?

What am I still unwilling to surrender?

Have I counted the cost of discipleship?

Am I growing in prayer, obedience, and love?

Do others see the love of Christ in my life?

- 01 Read these passages again slowly.
- 02 Ask God what needs to change in your life.
- 03 Choose one area where you need to obey Jesus more fully.
- 04 Follow Him daily, not only when it is easy.

PRAYER

Lord Jesus,

Thank You for calling me to follow You.

Teach me to deny myself, obey You daily, and love others
the way You love. Shape my life so that I may truly live as
Your disciple.

Amen.

N E X T

Lesson 4

Kingdom of God

Knowing God's rule, God's people, and God's purpose